Common Ground

The design edition. A card game for 2 to 6 people about building technology that does not harm the people it reaches.

TRAUMA-INFORMED TECHNOLOGY DESIGN

Global Disability Innovation Hub, UCL



Common Ground

2–6 players · about six minutes a round. Start with the rules card.

SETTING UP

2–6 players

22 DILEMMAS · 16 CONSTRAINTS · 12 PEOPLE · 7 PRINCIPLES · 6 TEAM · 6 PASSES

1 Shuffle the DILEMMAS and put them face down in the middle.

2 Shuffle the CONSTRAINTS and deal everyone a hand of three. Two each if there are five or six of you.

3 Shuffle the PEOPLE cards and put them face down beside the dilemmas.

4 Lay the seven PRINCIPLE cards face up where everyone can reach them, with the SIGNALS strip beside them.

5 Everyone takes a PASS card and keeps it face up in front of them.

6 Pick a Dealer. The role moves one to the left after every round.

Nobody is asked to talk about themselves

You play a card, not an experience. The PEOPLE cards are composites written for this deck, not transcripts of anyone's life. Nothing in this game requires you to have been there.

Turn over for how to play

HOW TO PLAY

A round

ROUGHLY SIX MINUTES

1 The Dealer reads the dilemma aloud. This is a decision a design team actually has to make.

2 **Make it worse.** Everyone plays one constraint from their hand, face down. With two players, play two each.

3 **Reveal together.** Turn them over at the same moment, so nobody sets the frame.

4 **Draw a person.** The Dealer turns over a PEOPLE card and reads it aloud. Nobody at this table chose who it would be.

5 **One sentence each.** What does this design, under these constraints, now do to them?

6 **Vote on three.** Point at the constraint that does most damage. Not your own. Most votes wins, the Dealer breaks a tie, and whoever played it takes a point.

7 **Find common ground.** The whole table agrees one sentence on what would have prevented it, files it under a PRINCIPLE, and names the SIGNAL it acts on. No points: this part belongs to everyone.

The worst constraint is the only thing scored. The common ground is not: it is agreed by everyone and belongs to everyone. Draw back up, pass the Dealer left.

Five rounds fills thirty minutes



Because we can

The team can infer someone's mental state from typing patterns. The accuracy is good and the data would be valuable. Nobody asked for it.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?

2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— Who asked for this, and who benefits from it existing?

— What happens the first time the inference is wrong about someone?

— What would have to be true for not building it to be the right call?



The general case

The brief says design for everyone. Nobody on the project has spoken to anyone who would be using this on the worst day of their life.

The two questions of every round

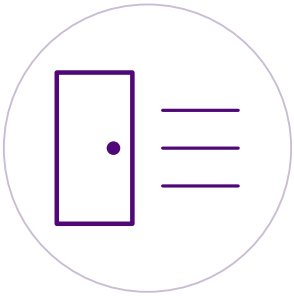
1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— Who did the team picture while designing this?

— What does 'everyone' exclude in practice?

— What is the cheapest thing that would change that, and why has it not happened?



The optional photo

Signup asks for a profile photo. It is optional. The skip link is grey, small, and below the fold.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— Who is this photo actually for?

— What does the design do to someone who has a reason not to be visible?

— Would you still call it optional if you measured how many people skip it?



Read it again to report it

To report an abusive message, the person has to open it, re-read it, and tick a box confirming what it said.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— Who is the confirmation step protecting, and from what?

— What could the system verify without making them look again?

— What does the flow cost the person it exists to help?



A year ago today

The app resurfaces photos and posts from the same date in previous years, on the home screen, automatically.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— What does the system know about why a year was hard, and what does it assume?

— Where is the control, and would anyone find it before the first resurfacing?

— What would opt-in cost the business, honestly?



We miss you

An automated email goes to accounts that have been dormant for ninety days.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— What are the reasons someone stops using a service?

— Which of those reasons does this email land badly on?

— Who is measured on the open rate?



The streak

A daily streak counter, with a small animation of a broken flame when the streak ends.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?

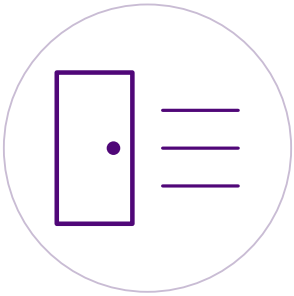
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— What is the streak measuring, and what does the person think it measures?

— What happens to someone who stops because they were unwell?

— Could the same engagement come from something that does not punish absence?



The shorter consent

Two consent flows were tested. The shorter one omits what happens to the data afterwards, and converts thirty per cent better.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— What exactly is the extra thirty per cent agreeing to?

— Is a test result a decision, and who is accountable for it?

— What would you have to believe for the short version to be the right call?



No visible way out

A VR module hides all controls during the session so the environment stays immersive.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?

2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— How does someone leave, and how do they know that before they start?

— What does immersion mean for someone who wants it to stop?

— What would a visible exit cost the experience?



The summary

An assistant automatically summarises long message threads. One thread is about a death in the family.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?

2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— Who asked for this thread to be summarised?

— What should the system do when it cannot tell what a thread is about?

— Is there a difference between summarising and repeating?



The canned reply

When a message mentions self-harm, the chatbot replies with a safety notice and closes the conversation.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— What does closing the conversation communicate?

— Who is the safety notice written for?

— What should happen instead, and who builds it?



Captions nobody can correct

Captions are generated automatically. There is no way for anyone to fix them, including the person who was speaking.

The two questions of every round

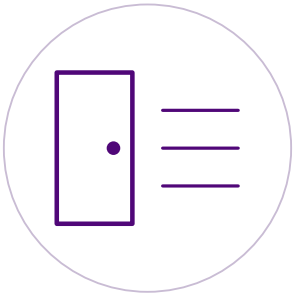
1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— Whose record is this, and who gets to correct it?

— What does an uncorrected transcript do over months?

— What would editing cost, and who decided that was too much?



Required before anything

Date of birth, gender and relationship status are required fields before the person can see the service at all.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?

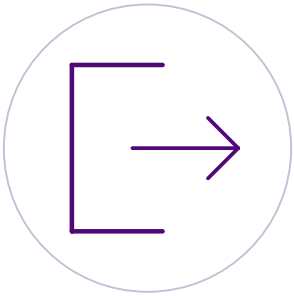
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— Which of these does the service genuinely need, and for what?

— What happens to someone whose answer does not fit the options?

— Who asked for these fields, and are they still here?



Delete means hide

The delete account button deactivates the profile. The data stays, indefinitely, in case the person comes back.

The two questions of every round

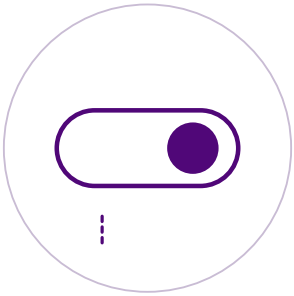
1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— What does the person believe they just did?

— Who benefits from the gap between the word and the behaviour?

— What would real deletion require, and what is actually stopping it?



The lock screen

The app stays signed in and shows message previews on the lock screen. Both are on by default.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?

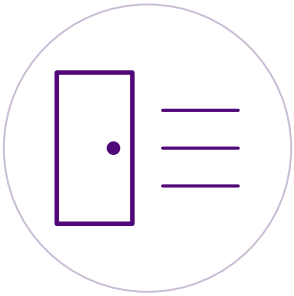
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— Who else can see this phone?

— What does the default assume about where people live?

— How many taps to change it, and would anyone find them?



Verify with your face

Identity verification requires a live face scan. There is no alternative route.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— Who is excluded by the only route being this one?

— What happens when the check fails and there is nobody to ask?

— What is being verified, and is there another way to establish it?



The progress bar that lies

A progress bar fills smoothly, then the process fails at ninety-nine per cent with a generic error.

The two questions of every round

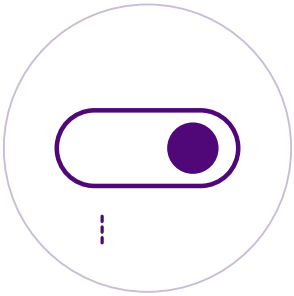
1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— What is the bar actually showing?

— What does someone conclude when it fails that late?

— What should the interface say when it does not know?



Seen by

Read receipts and 'seen by' indicators are on by default and cannot be turned off individually.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— What obligation does a read receipt create?

— Who does that obligation fall hardest on?

— Why is it all-or-nothing?



The report goes nowhere

Reports are received and acted on, but the person who reported never hears what happened.

The two questions of every round

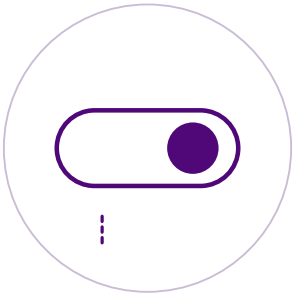
1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— What does silence tell someone who reported something serious?

— What could be said without compromising the process?

— Who decided this was a communications problem rather than a design one?



Location, on by default

Precise location sharing is enabled at install, with a one-line notice during setup.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— Who is made findable by this default?

— What is the feature for, and does it need precision?

— What would the product lose if it were off until asked for?



Celebrate five years with us

An anniversary email goes to every account on the date it was created.

The two questions of every round

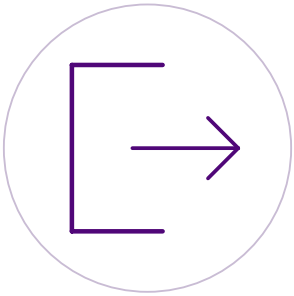
1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?
2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— What might those five years have contained?

— What does the system know about why the account was opened?

— Is there a version of this that waits to be asked?



Tell us why you are leaving

Before the account can be closed, the person must choose a reason from a dropdown.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: what does this do to the person on the PEOPLE card?

2. Together: what would have prevented it?

If the room stalls

— Who is the question for?

— What does a required exit survey do to someone leaving because of harm?

— What would make this an invitation rather than a gate?

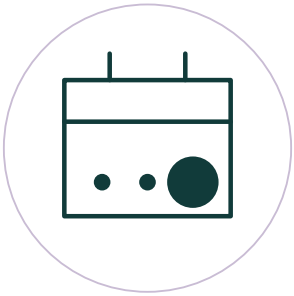


The metric you are measured on is weekly active users.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



It ships in two weeks and the date has been announced.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

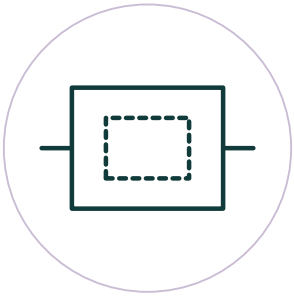


An A/B test decided this, not a person.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



The model is a third-party API and nobody on the team can see inside it.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



Legal requires the field.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

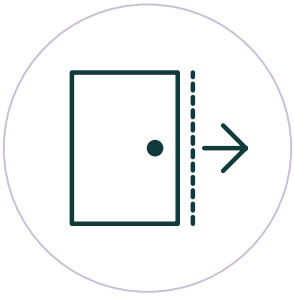


It already shipped to four million people.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

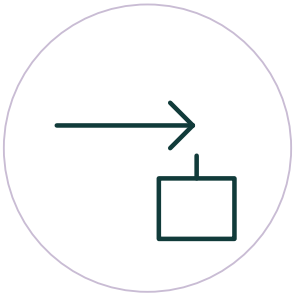


Whoever designed this flow has left.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

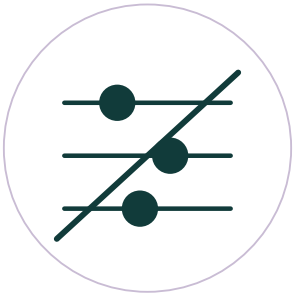


Accessibility review happens after design sign-off.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

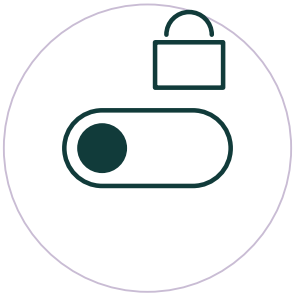


There is no setting for it.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

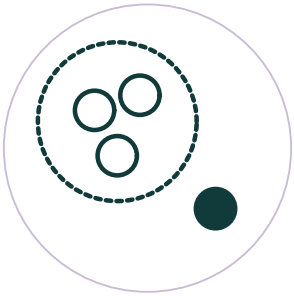


It is a default, and almost nobody changes defaults.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



Nobody on the team uses the product the way this person does.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



The copy was written by someone who never saw the screen.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



It works fine on the devices the team carries.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



Support will absorb it, and support is outsourced.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

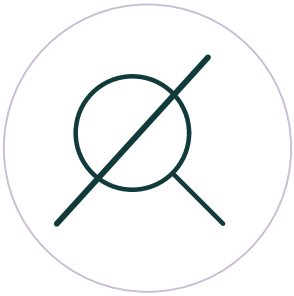


It is already in the press release.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



The research that would have caught this was cut.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Constraint

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

A design decision is made under pressure, and then it meets somebody. That is the order these cards exist to reproduce: you commit first, and find out who it reaches afterwards.

Read the card aloud, in full, before anyone speaks.

These are composites written for this deck. They are not transcripts, and no card describes a real individual. Say so when you introduce them.



People

Composites, not transcripts.



“I share this account with my ex-partner. He still knows the password. Every month you email a summary of everything I have booked.”

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



“I use voice control for everything. Your error sound is pitched so sharply that I brace before every command, and there is no setting for it.”

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



“I am Deaf. Your captions are automatic and nobody can correct them, so the record of my own meeting has my name wrong in forty places.”

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



“I am autistic. Things on your screen slide, fade and reflow while I am reading them. By the time I find what I need, I have lost what I came for.”

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



“My son died in March. In October your app put his face on my home screen and called it a memory.”

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



“I left a controlling relationship last year. Your suggestions offered him my profile, and I have no way of knowing what it offered him.”

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



“I live in temporary accommodation and the phone is shared with my children. Your previews appear on the lock screen and the setting is buried.”

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



“I have a tremor. Your confirm and delete buttons are the same size, side by side, and there is no undo.”

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



“English is my fourth language. Your error says 'something went wrong' and nothing else, so I do not know whether the money has gone.”

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



“I use a screen reader. Your new design announces every decorative icon before the content, so a two-minute task takes twenty.”

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



“I am seeking asylum and my documents do not match the formats your identity check accepts. There is no route to a person.”

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



“I left your platform because of harassment. Six months later you emailed to say you missed me.”

Nobody at this table chose who it would be

People

Shuffle face down. Draw one after the reveal.



Safety

Everyone the design reaches feels physically and psychologically safe using it.

The question to put to the fix

Does this work for someone on a shared device, in temporary housing, or with somebody watching the screen?

Safety is read by the body before it is read by the mind. Light, pace, sound and motion are doing that work whether or not anyone designed them to.

SAMHSA, Concept of Trauma and Guidance for a Trauma-Informed Approach, 2014



Trustworthiness and transparency

The design tells the truth about what it does, before and after it does it.

The question to put to the fix

Does the person know what will happen before it happens, and does the interface say honestly what it did?

A word that does not match the behaviour behind it is the most expensive thing in any interface. Delete should delete.



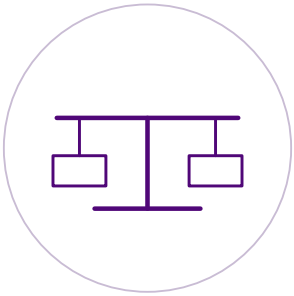
Peer support

People with shared experience are a route to safety, not an afterthought.

The question to put to the fix

Does this connect people to others who have been here, or route everything back through the company?

Peer routes that are unpaid, unmoderated or unsupported move the work rather than sharing it.



Collaboration and mutuality

Power differences are levelled, including the ones built into a default.

The question to put to the fix

Who set this default, and can the person change it without a fight?

A default is a decision made on someone's behalf by a person they will never meet.



Empowerment, voice and choice

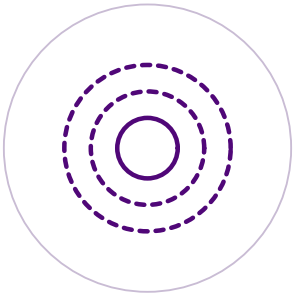
Strengths are recognised and the choice on offer is a real one.

The table's common ground is filed here

The question to put to the fix

Is this a genuine choice, or a choice between using the service as designed and going without?

Where there is no alternative service, consent is not meaningfully given. Design as though the person cannot walk away, because some of them cannot.



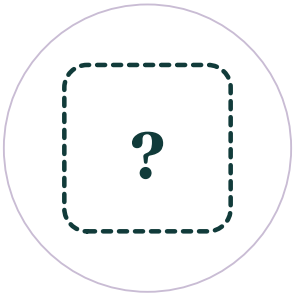
Cultural, historical and gender issues

Stereotypes are moved past, and history is recognised rather than repeated.

The question to put to the fix

Whose normal shaped this flow, and who does it quietly treat as an exception?

The form field that has no right answer for someone is not a small problem for them.



None of these fit

The six do not name what this fix actually does.

Keep these: they are an output

The question to put to the fix

So what does it serve? Say it plainly, and say what the set is missing.

A principle set that cannot name your fix is a finding about the principle set. Keep these.

Safety is read by the body before it is read by the mind. When you agree the common ground, name which of these it acts on.

- [ ] **Light and contrast**
  Brightness, glare, dark patterns of a literal kind.
- [ ] **Pace and interruption**
  How fast it moves, and whether it waits.
- [ ] **Tone, pitch and prosody**
  How a voice or a sound lands before the words do.
- [ ] **Motion and animation**
  What moves without being asked to.
- [ ] **Sound and alert**
  What it does to a body in a quiet room.
- [ ] **Haptics and force**
  Vibration, resistance, the physical demand of a control.
- [ ] **Density and load**
  How much arrives at once.
- [ ] **Irreversibility**
  What cannot be undone, and how clearly that is signalled.

Signals

Light, pace, tone, motion, sound, haptics, density, irreversibility.



Product manager

Decides what ships, what is cut, and what the team is measured on.

Is this perspective anywhere in the library?

— Controls scope, the release date, and which metric counts as success.

— Sees the dashboard and the roadmap.

— Cannot see the person at the other end of a number that went up.

Lay all six face up at the end and ask whose view is missing from the library. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



Engineer

Knows what can actually be changed, and how quickly.

Is this perspective anywhere in the library?

— Controls what is technically possible this sprint and what is a rewrite.

— Sees the error logs and the edge cases nobody designed for.

— Cannot see why a decision was made before they joined.

Lay all six face up at the end and ask whose view is missing from the library. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



Designer

Sets the defaults, the wording, and what the interface does without being asked.

Is this perspective anywhere in the library?

— Controls the default state, the copy, and what is made easy or hard.

— Sees the flow as a whole.

— Cannot see it on a cracked phone, in a shelter, with someone watching.

Lay all six face up at the end and ask whose view is missing from the library. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



Trust and safety

Handles what happens after the design meets someone it did not expect.

Is this perspective anywhere in the library?

— Controls escalation, and what counts as a violation.

— Sees the reports, the patterns, and the worst of it.

— Cannot see the design decision that produced the report, six months earlier.

Lay all six face up at the end and ask whose view is missing from the library. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



Legal and data protection

Decides what must be collected, kept, and disclosed.

Is this perspective anywhere in the library?

— Controls which fields are mandatory and how long data is held.

— Sees the regulatory requirement.

— Cannot see what a required field does to someone it does not describe.

Lay all six face up at the end and ask whose view is missing from the library. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



The person who cannot leave

Uses the service because there is no alternative: a benefits portal, a landlord's app, a hospital system.

Is this perspective anywhere in the library?

— Controls nothing, and consents to everything, because the option is to go without.

— Sees exactly how the design behaves when it goes wrong.

— Cannot opt out, complain to anyone who can change it, or go elsewhere.

Lay all six face up at the end and ask whose view is missing from the library. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



Play it whenever you like

To skip a dilemma, sit out a round, or leave the table. No reason, no cost, and you pick it straight back up.

It is a move, not a withdrawal. There is no limit on how often you play it.

Pass

One each. Unlimited use.



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